

See also

Read about ants, who are also ruled by a dominant queen (78–79), and bats, another small mammal that lives in big groups (128–129).

Mature males

Unlike female workers, males stay fertile so they can father babies. When males wander into the burrows from other colonies, the queen selects her favorites and mates with them.

Workers and soldiers

Babies grow up to become the workers of the colony. At first, they dig tunnels and collect food. As they get older, they become soldiers, defending the burrows from intruders.

Termites These sociable insects live in colonies dominated by a breeding queen and have workers to look after the nest or hive. Some termite species live in mounds, which have complex systems of tunnels.

The worker in front uses its teeth to dig, while others behind it kick the loose soil back.

The most dominant naked mole rats are the ones who win shoving matches inside the tunnels.

New colonies form when tunnels get closed off and a new queen takes over on the other side.

